Vahid Moghani

Postdoctoral Researcher, Erasmus School of Economics and Tinbergen Institute

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Academic Positions

Postdoctoral Researcher — 2024 - *2027*
Erasmus School of Economics and *Tinbergen Institute*

Education

Ph.D., *Erasmus School of Economics* and *Tinbergen Institute* — 2019 - 2024
Supervisors: Pilar García-Gómez and Tom Van Ourti

MPhil in Economics, *Tinbergen Institute* — 2017 - 2019
Major in Econometrics, *graduated with distinction*

M.Sc. in Economics, *Sharif University of Technology* — 2014 - 2017

B.Sc. in Aerospace Engineering, *Sharif University of Technology* — 2008 - 2013
Minor in Mathematics

Visiting Positions

Visiting Researcher, **Institute for Fiscal Studies**, London — Spring 2026
Visiting Graduate Student, **Brown University**, Providence — Spring 2024

Research Interests

Health economics, labor economics, and econometrics

References

Pilar García-Gómez, Erasmus School of Economics, garciagomez@ese.eur.nl
Sonia Bhalotra, University of Warwick, Sonia.Bhalotra@warwick.ac.uk
Owen O'Donnell, Erasmus School of Economics, odonnell@ese.eur.nl
Aurélien Baillon, emlyon business school, baillon@em-lyon.com

Working Papers

The Health Costs of Firms (*Job Market Paper*)
Single-authored.

Abstract. This paper estimates how much firms differ in their contribution to otherwise similar workers' healthcare expenditure. Using linked Dutch employer-employee data, I exploit worker moves across firms to separate persistent worker and firm differences. Moving the same worker to a firm one standard deviation higher in the firm-effect distribution raises expected annual expenditure by 17.8%. The implied top-bottom quintile gap is comparable to gradients by income, wealth, and education, and over half of the dispersion lies within narrowly defined industries. Supporting a health-risk interpretation, workers who move to firms with higher coworker expenditure increase use of pain, anti-inflammatory, and muscle relaxant medications, and exposure to high-effect firms predicts disability and mortality, including among workers displaced by closures. High-effect firms pay higher wage premia, but mainly between rather than within industries. Because basic healthcare is collectively financed, the results point to a fiscal externality: firms generate healthcare expenditure they do not fully bear.

When Is the Mover-Design Event Study Coefficient a Place-Effect Share? (*Companion Paper to the Job Market Paper*)
Single-authored. Tinbergen Institute Discussion Paper 26-056.

Abstract. Mover-design event studies are a leading approach to separating place effects from sorting. The coefficient is often interpreted as the share of cross-sectional variation in location means due to places. I show the coefficient depends on how movers connect locations: two economies can be identical in place effects, sorting, and location means, yet deliver different mover coefficients. Only under *directional isotropy*, a testable condition, does the coefficient permit a cross-sectional reading: it averages the variance share of place effects and the share that equalizing them removes. An illustration in Dutch employer-employee wage data rejects the condition.

Disambiguating Information Interventions

With Aurélien Baillon and Francesco Capozza.

Abstract. Information experiments read reported probabilities as beliefs. When the odds are unknown, a reported probability also reflects two ambiguity attitudes: aversion pushes it in the pessimistic direction; coarse perception pulls it toward one half. Information changes these attitudes as well as the belief, so a change in a reported probability is not a change in belief. We characterize the designs that identify the belief and both attitudes. A single elicited probability does not identify even the sign of the belief change; we give the threshold beyond which the sign is trustworthy. A known six-bet design identifies all three, run once in each information condition. We use it in a randomized experiment in a Dutch population panel, betting on a matched panel member's doctor visits. At face value, the reported probabilities show no detectable effect, which is not evidence about beliefs. Recovered beliefs show improved predictive accuracy and lower ambiguity aversion.

Mental Health Literacy, Beliefs and Demand for Support among University Students (*Revise & Resubmit, Experimental Economics*)

With Michelle Acampora and Francesco Capozza.

Abstract. This paper assesses the impact of a mental health literacy intervention on the demand for mental health support among university students. We run a field experiment with 2,978 students at a large Dutch university. The intervention raises willingness to pay and demand for a mental-health app among male respondents, and shifts information demand from psychological counselling toward coaching, driven by students with moderate distress. Increased perceived effectiveness of low-intensity therapy appears to be the mechanism. A three-week follow-up suggests a moderate improvement in mental-health scores for treated female students, consistent with higher care-seeking.

Combining Boundary and Interior Information in Ordered Multi-Threshold Regression Discontinuity Designs

With Saeed Badri.

Abstract. Ordered multi-threshold regression discontinuity designs often require aggregating local discontinuities across several known cutoffs. This paper shows that such aggregate parameters can be decomposed into boundary terms and smooth contrasts between adjacent thresholds. Interior observations do not identify a single RD jump, but they are informative about these smooth segment contrasts. We develop an integrated-derivative estimator for segment contrasts by numerically integrating nonparametric estimates of the derivative of the conditional mean between adjacent thresholds. We derive its asymptotic distribution, including the leading bias and a feasible variance formula. The main result shows that the integrated-derivative estimator is asymptotically independent of the corresponding boundary-level estimator for the same smooth contrast. This independence yields a transparent inverse-variance combination of boundary and interior signals. The combined estimator is an augmentation of boundary-level estimation and is most useful when boundary information is sparse or noisy. Simulations confirm the distributional approximation and show modest gains under regular designs and larger gains in sparse-boundary designs.

Childhood Mental Health Effects of Early-Life Exposure to a Parental Job Loss (*Draft available upon request*)

With Pilar García-Gómez and Tom Van Ourti.

Abstract. We study the mental health effects of early life exposure to paternal job loss. Using nationwide individual-level administrative register records, we focus on firm-closure-induced job losses for fathers with children below age five in the Netherlands. These children are more likely to take mental health-related medicines in their later childhood, and this increase is mainly driven by psychostimulant drugs. The increased uptake of psychostimulants ranges from 15 percent of mean uptake in the control group at age five to around 9 percent at age twelve. The effects are significantly larger for families with mothers being the main breadwinner, suggesting that the drop in paternal income resulting from displacement is not the main driver of psychostimulant uptake. We further find that the father is more likely to take mental health medication around the time of job loss, and that the children exposed to paternal job loss are more likely to live in dissolved families. We find no evidence of exposed children living in neighborhoods with different rates of psychostimulant consumption compared to control children, while parents of treated children do report more impulsive behavior and inattention symptoms.

Publications

- **Antipsychotic Exposure and Pharmacologically Treated Type 2 Diabetes in Dutch Youths** (with R. N. Gangapersad, P. García-Gómez, B. C. P. Koch, B. Dierckx), *JAMA Network Open*, 2026.

Work in Progress

- **Mental Models of Mental Health** (with *S. Bhalotra* and *F. Capozza*)
- **Female Practice Ownership and Women's Care: Evidence from Local Variation in Practice Owners** (with *E. de Weerd*)
- **Do Patients or Physicians Drive Variation in Medication Costs in India?** (with *A. Bhaskarabhatla, O. O'Donnell* and *S. Thakur*)
- **Dutch Colorectal Cancer Screening Program: Policy Learning under Equality Concerns and Capacity Constraints** (with *I. Lansdorp-Vogelaar, O. O'Donnell, M. Robson, E. Toes-Zoutendijk, R. Van Gestel* and *T. Van Ourti*)

Software & Reproducibility

- `LeaveOutKSS` (CRAN): R package implementing leave-out (KSS) variance and covariance estimators for AKM two-way fixed effects (Kline, Saggio & Sølvsten, *Econometrica*, 2020). Used in *The Health Costs of Firms*.

Advanced Training (selected)

- CEMFI: Experiments in Complex Systems (Stefan Wager) and Unstructured Data (Stephen Hansen)
- Tinbergen Institute: Causal Inference & ML (Guido Imbens) and Measure Theory & Asymptotics (Peter Spreij)
- University of Amsterdam: Asymptotic Statistics (Bas Kleijn)

Grants

- **Erasmus Initiative "Smarter Choices for Better Health"** (Co-applicant), *Socioeconomic determinants of psychotropic medication use in children and adolescents*, **€150,000**, 2022-2026.
- **Seed Grant Scheme, Erasmus Initiative "Smarter Choices for Better Health"**, data access for *Dutch Colorectal Cancer Screening Program: Policy Learning under Equality Concerns and Capacity Constraints*, **€15,000**, December 2024.
- **LISS Panel Grant** (in-kind data collection), *Measuring Uncertainty Perception in the Health Domain*, 2024 (with A. Baillon and F. Capozza).
- **EsCHER Event Funding** (Erasmus Centre for Health Economics Rotterdam), organization of the *4th Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop*, **€1,500**, 2026.
- **Building New Blocks** (Co-lead with F. Capozza), *Information and Demand for Mental Health Support among University Students*, **€5,000**, 2021.

Presentations

2026: EEA-ESEM Congress, 31st International Panel Data Conference (IPDC), American-European Health Economics Study Group (X Edition), and an invited seminar at emlyon business school.

2025: European Economic Association Congress and an invited talk at the University of Basel.

2024: European Society for Population Economics, European Workshop on Econometrics and Health Economics, and Second Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop.

2023: ifo Dresden Workshop on Labor Economics and Social Policy and IZA Summer School in Labor Economics.

2022: IRDES-Dauphine AHEPE Workshop, EUHEA, Essen Economics of Mental Health Workshop, and ESE Young Staff Workshop (with Guido Imbens).

2021: Barcelona GSE Summer Forum, ASHEcon, and AES-APES VECR.

2020: Essen Economics of Mental Health Workshop and Essen Health Economics Conference.

Teaching

Practical AI for Research: Large Language Models and Unstructured Data (Organizer and Lecturer), ERIM Summer Course, Erasmus University Rotterdam	2026	Summer
Seminar in Health Economics (Lecturer), Erasmus School of Economics	2024-present	Spring
Economics of the Welfare State (Lecturer), Erasmus School of Economics	2021-2023	Fall
Economics of the Welfare State (Tutorial Leader), Erasmus School of Economics	2019-2020	Fall
Microeconomics I (Teaching Assistant), Tinbergen Institute	2018	Fall

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Service & Organization

Co-organizer and scientific committee member, 4th Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop, Rotterdam, September 2026.

Referee: *The Economic Journal, Journal of Health Economics, Health Economics.*

Erasmus School of Economics: PhD Council (2022), PhD Wellbeing Working Group (2021).

Honours & Awards

Teaching Assistant of the Year Prize at Tinbergen Institute	2019
Ranked 6th of over 40,000 in the National M.Sc. Entrance Exam in Economics	2014
Ranked in the Top 1% of the National B.Sc. Entrance Exam	2008